



One captain on another: "Gill is supremely skilled and mentally very strong. That combination is dangerous," says Kishore. **R.V. MOORTHY**

than 10 years ago. Back then, batters wouldn't counter-attack. They would grind you all day, like Cheteshwar Pujara or others of that mould. Now, that grinding element has faded. The white-ball game has brought in more risk-taking.

It's not unfortunate — it was bound to happen. When you play six months of T20 cricket, singles lose their value. They're useful, yes, but they're not 'gold'. The real currency is fours and sixes.

So, a back-foot punch or a cover drive — low-risk, traditional shots — are less valued than a reverse sweep. Naturally, players would rather switch-hit because there's no third man, only a slip.

The problem is that if you don't practise those low-risk shots for six months, you can't suddenly produce

them in a one-month red-ball tournament. That's why the skill has dipped. But at the same time, it can be a positive. England plays this high-risk style and succeeds. If someone here can adopt it fully, they can become a complete game-changer. You might get out first ball, but if it clicks, the match is over.

That's what I try to emphasise. Don't fall into the trap of thinking you'll suddenly become a traditional player in a month. Instead, double down on what you do best — be even more aggressive. If it fails, no problem, I'll back you to play the same way next game. But make sure the bowler feels you're coming after him. That mindset itself can tilt the contest.

What did you make of Shubman Gill's captaincy — especially the switch from IPL to Test cricket?

Shubman is a prodigy. I've known him since he was 16. The first time we played him in Under-19s, he

scored 260 in Patiala. Later, in the Ranji Trophy, he got 270. Honestly, it took me four years to figure him out. I even went back to my coach, Ram Kumar, and said: There's this guy who's just smashing me around — what can I do? I had to change my trajectory and work on new things purely because of Shubman. I've told him this story too.

Credit goes to his father for shaping him. From childhood, he was made to play every shot mercilessly. He's supremely skilled, but what makes him exceptional is that he's also mentally very strong. That combination is dangerous. And he's taken to captaincy like a fish to water.

Remember, he had never even captained Punjab because he was always with India. But when the Indian team needed a leader, Shubman stepped in.

I'm very happy to see how naturally he's adapted. Hopefully, in the coming years, he'll grow into a proper leader.